

Up to London



Apple seller

IN THE 1580s, Shakespeare said goodbye to his family in Stratford and set off to seek his fortune in London. He was just one of thousands of country people who moved to the great city in the late 16th century. He found himself in a bustling, crowded place, with narrow, dark streets littered with all kinds of garbage. As a newcomer, Shakespeare would have been struck by the noise, the dirt, and the smells of the city. Crossing London Bridge, he might have been shocked by the sight of the heads of executed traitors rotting on poles. He would also have been impressed by the beauty of the grand churches and the riverside mansions of London's wealthy merchants and nobles.

Walking near the Thames River, Shakespeare would have been greeted by the watermen's shouts of "Westward ho!" and "Eastward ho!" as they called for passengers. The watermen rowed Londoners up and down the river, and across to Bankside and back. The Thames was crowded with boats of all sizes, including the gilded royal barge taking Queen Elizabeth to and from her palace at Greenwich.

WESTWARD HO!

A waterman was like a 16th-century taxi driver

Watermen worked either alone or in pairs



A view of London from the south, by Dutch artist Claes Jans Visscher, c. 1616

Every day, thousands of people were rowed across the river to the playhouses at Bankside

SPREADING CITY

When Shakespeare came to London, most people lived in the old part of the city on the north side of the Thames River, still surrounded by medieval walls. But London was spreading fast in all directions, swelled by the rising number of incomers. Bankside, on the south bank of the river, was rapidly becoming London's main entertainment center.